

Auwa Figure — Production & Editions

Created 26 August 2026 from the figure production session. The single source of truth for how the figure is made, finished, packaged, priced and sold, and for how the artist collab editions work.

Load together with `context/website/store.md` (the product page), `context/business/business.md` §6.2 and §6.2a (shelf and collab programme), `context/brand/brand.md` (voice and palette) and `context/business/japan.md` (the exhibition and maker ladder). `context/brand/reference.md` holds the older collectible-figure rules and the Fin DAC relationship background.

Shortcut phrases that should load this file: "figure", "figure drop", "figure production", "packaging", "collab", "Fin DAC".

WHAT IT IS

A hand-finished collectible figure of the Auwa character, made by Rieko in small numbered editions that are never reissued. **The figure is Rieko's project end to end.** She prints, sands, stains, finishes, signs, packs and sources. Tom guides, photographs, prices and sells.

Measured, 26 Aug 2026: 10cm tall, 6.5cm wide, 6cm deep, excluding the base.

That size is settled and should not be reopened. It sits in the middle of the shelf collectors already live on (Sonny Angel ~8cm, 100% Bearbrick ~7cm, kokeshi 10-15cm), it fills the palm because of the width rather than the height, and it posts in a small parcel. The one cost of staying small is that £200+ is easier to justify at 15cm on presence alone, so the base, the box and the story have to carry more of the argument. They can.

STATUS (26 August 2026)

Blender model complete. Multiple prototypes printed on the BambuLab in four materials. Material decided, finish route decided, packaging material decided. Nothing yet tested for stain,

wax, sanding time, embossed numbering, weight or transit. No supplier contacted. Photographs shot from a June Instagram post and a set of desk prototypes; no product photography exists.

Target drop: mid-November 2026. The long pole is photography, which cannot happen until finished pieces and a real box exist.

MATERIAL — DECIDED

Bambu PLA Wood. White Oak (13106) for the natural, and White Oak stained dark for the sumi (see FINISH).

allPHA is dead. Fiddly to print, the surface reads oily, and its heat tolerance is a real worry on a sunlit shelf. Beyond that, biodegradability is a liability rather than an asset on an object sold as never reissued and made to keep. Do not reopen it.

PLA Basic Black (10101) is not the answer for the dark version either. It prints and looks good, but it breaks the material story: a page that says wood composite next to a figure that is plainly black plastic invites the one question you do not want.

How to talk about it, and this matters. PLA Wood is mostly PLA with wood fibre in it. Never imply otherwise, and do not lean on the eco angle, which is the weakest argument available and the one a sceptical buyer will pick at. The strong reasons are all true and all checkable: it sands like timber instead of gumming like plastic, it takes stain, the grain rises as the finish goes on, and it is warm rather than cold in the hand. The material card copy already on the store preview page ("Fine wood fibre held in a plant-based polymer") is correct as written.

Production note. Wood-filled filament is abrasive and clog-prone. Confirm a hardened steel nozzle before committing to a run. A nozzle failing at unit 19 with a drop date behind you is a bad week.

FINISH — DECIDED IN PRINCIPLE, TESTS OUTSTANDING

Sanded, not fuzzy. Fuzzy skin is ruled out permanently and the reason is technical rather than aesthetic: fuzzy skin only perturbs the vertical outer walls. The crown of the head is a top solid surface, so the converging seam appears there on every print regardless of the setting, and sanding it out removes the fuzz at the single most visible point on the object. No printer setting fixes this.

That makes sanding the only route, which makes **layer height the most important production lever available**. Print time is machine hours and costs nothing but patience. Sanding is Rieko's hands and it dominates the labour. Test 0.2mm against 0.08mm and buy back sanding time with print time.

Wax, not oil. Raw surface is not an option: it is porous, takes finger grease unevenly and pale PLA yellows in daylight over years. Oil darkens and shines, which is exactly what was disliked about the allPHA. A clear matte hard wax buffed dry keeps the chalky look and seals the surface. Test bare, camellia oil and wax before locking.

The sumi is stained, not painted. Wood-filled PLA takes wood stain far better than plain PLA, especially once sanding exposes fibre at the surface. An ebonised finish goes near-black with the grain still showing under it. That gives one material and two hand-applied finishes, which is a far better story than two filaments, and it makes the name Sumi mean something. If stain will not sit, the fallback is a hand-applied matte black, described honestly as a finish rather than a material.

THE TWO VERSIONS

Natural and **Sumi**. Numbered within each colourway, not across the edition ("Natural, 1 of 15"), which reads better and gives two sell-out moments.

The natural blank is philosophically the hero. In the stories Auwa's light reveals what is already inside a thing, and the whole collab programme rests on a blank that someone else reveals. The design should treat natural as canonical rather than as one of two equal options.

Open question, and it should be settled before the page copy is written. The black resonated with people unexpectedly (June Instagram post, several unprompted comments) and Rieko now plans to introduce a black Auwa in the books. If the black exists in the stories then it is a **character, not a colourway**, and two characters is a much stronger proposition than one figure in two finishes: each gets its own name, its own numbering and its own reason to be owned. This decision changes the naming, the store copy and possibly the edition split. Settle it with the books first.

THE BASE — REAL WOOD, NOT PRINTED

The highest-leverage decision on the object. A printed base is the weakest element in every prototype photograph.

Specification: a turned hardwood disc or low plinth, roughly 9cm across, with a slight chamfer and shallow blind holes matching the feet so the figure seats positively without glue and lifts out cleanly. Hinoki or keyaki.

It does four jobs at once. It adds mass, which the figure needs. It adds a material a printer cannot fake. It gives the signature a home. And it stops the eye reading "printed" the moment the object is picked up.

The strategic part: source it from a woodturner in Japan. Forty small turned discs is a trivial job for a turner, costs very little, and means the object is genuinely part-made by a Japanese hand rather than described that way. It is also an easy first commission for Rieko to write in Japanese and a rehearsal for the craftsman outreach. If Japan is too slow for November, use a UK turner for edition one and switch for edition two.

Metal bases are parked, not rejected. Metal solves the weight problem instantly and blackened steel or brass under the sumi would look excellent. But introducing a second material family in edition one splits the story at the moment it most needs to be simple, and metal is heavier to post. Its right use is later, as the signal that a piece is a *different object*: brass under an artist edition, blackened steel under a collab. Changing the base is a much cheaper way to differentiate an edition than changing the figure.

NUMBERING AND SIGNING

The number goes **on the figure**, not only on the base. Base-only numbering is the weaker option and collectors notice, because a separate base can be swapped.

Method: emboss the edition number into the model on the underside of the torso, between the legs, and slice each unit individually. They are printed one at a time anyway, so the labour is a minute in the slicer, and the number becomes permanent and part of the object rather than applied to it. Test that it comes out crisp at small size before committing.

Then Rieko hand-signs the base with the matching number, and the hand-written card carries it too. Three marks that agree. A swapped base becomes obvious rather than undetectable.

Order a small custom brass stamp of the Auwa mark. One mark, used on the base, the box lid and the card. Three brand touchpoints from one cheap object.

PACKAGING

Kiribako (桐箱), not balsa. This is a correction to every earlier context file. Balsa is model-aircraft wood: extremely soft, no cultural meaning, and it will arrive dented. Kiri (paulownia) is what Japan puts tea ware, dolls, kimono and swords in. It is light, it handles humidity, it is inexpensive as a standard item, and to any Japanese person a kiribako says the thing inside matters before the lid is off. Japanese collectors keep the box with the piece, and a piece without its original box is worth measurably less.

Confirmed by sample. The KAWS Kokeshi box is a kiribako, and a Waso osechi box kept on 26 Aug 2026 is almost certainly the same wood: pale blond with a satiny lustre, straight open grain, and coarse open pores visible on the cut edges, which is a hardwood structure rather than spruce or hinoki. It carries no maker mark. Kiri is also startlingly light for its size and nearly odourless, where anything in the pine family smells resinous.

Specification. Roughly **14cm square by 10-11cm tall**, thicker walls than a food box, and a properly fitted lid, the kind that settles slowly because the air has to escape. That resistance is a real part of the experience. Ask for a single-board lid rather than an edge-joined one; it costs a little more and looks considerably better. Base diameter sets the footprint, not the figure.

Layout, and it is not the obvious one. Do not stand the figure on its base inside the box. Standing puts every courier jolt through the legs, which are the thinnest and most brittle part of the object. Instead: the base lies flat in a recess at the bottom, the figure lies above it in a felt cradle that supports the body rather than the legs, and the card sits on top. Opening runs obi band, lid, card, wrapped figure, base beneath.

That is a better object anyway, because the buyer seats the figure onto its base themselves. It is a small ritual and it is the moment the thing becomes theirs rather than something that arrived assembled.

The rest of the package. A washi obi band wrapped around the box carries the logo, edition and number, which brands the box without marking the wood and can change between editions for nothing. The figure is wrapped in undyed cotton or washi. A laser-cut wool felt cradle holds it. A hand-written card from Rieko sits on top.

Transit is a real risk, not a footnote. Kiri dents easily and PLA legs are brittle. The kiribako must travel inside a plain outer carton with void fill, and that carton is part of the unit cost. Post one to a friend abroad, boxed as it would be sold, before selling anything.

COST AND LABOUR

Materials per figure, estimated 26 Aug 2026. Base and box are the two to hold loosely until quotes come back.

Item	Estimate
Filament (~55g inc. waste and purge)	£1.50
Sandpaper, stain, wax, brushes	£1.00
Turned wooden base	£5-12
Kiribako	£8-15
Washi obi band	£1.00
Card and inner wrap	£2.00
Felt cradle	£1.50
Outer carton and void fill	£2.50
Total	£23-36, working figure £29

Postage sits on top: roughly £6-8 UK tracked, £15-25 international with customs paperwork.

Note the shape of that. The printed figure is the cheapest component by a wide margin, and about 90% of the material cost is the base, the box and what surrounds them. That is the correct shape for this product and it is also the honest answer to anyone asking why a 3D print costs £220. It doesn't. The object does.

Labour per figure (Rieko's hands only; machine time is not labour).

Print handling and plate cleaning 10 min. Support removal and cleanup 10. Sanding 30-45. Staining (sumi only) 10 plus drying. Wax and buff 10. Eyes 8. Number check and deburr 3. Base fitting 5. Signing 2. Writing the card 6. Wrapping, cradling, boxing, obi, outer carton, label 14. Order admin 4.

About 2 hours per figure, 2h10 for a sumi, realistically 2.5 including reject prints at roughly one in ten. Across 30 that is **60-75 hours**, or about three weeks of Rieko doing nothing else.

PRICE

Recommended: £220, VAT inclusive. Hard floor £195. (Was a £180 placeholder; that number is too low and nothing has been published.)

At Rieko's £550 day rate, two hours is roughly £157 of labour against a £180 price that nets only £150 after VAT. Add £29 of materials and edition one loses money on paper before postage and fees. £220 nets £183, which covers materials and about half the labour.

What justifies it, and all of it is visible: £25 of base and packaging, two hours of the artist's own hands, an edition of 30 that never repeats, a commissioned Japanese wooden base, a signature and a hand-written card. The £150-180 band is where independent resin artists sit, and they cast from a mould in minutes. This is not that.

The counter-argument, recorded honestly: a sell-out matters more than margin for edition one, because the sell-out creates the waitlist and the scarcity that edition two trades on. If £220 would turn a sell-out into 70%, take £195. With 30 units against ~2,700 Instagram followers and the lottery list, £220 should still sell out.

VAT. More Air Limited is VAT registered, so 20% applies from the first UK sale with no threshold. All prices are set VAT inclusive. Exports outside the UK are zero-rated. See `context/business/structure.md`.

SELLING MODEL

A timed drop, made to order. Announce a date, open ordering for a fixed window or until 30 are claimed, state a three-week lead time plainly, and make against paid orders.

Thirty finished pieces before a single sale is three weeks of Rieko's hands and all of the cash risk, and it is the exact pattern that has stalled things here before. You need about five finished pieces to open: the photography set plus a spare. Nobody in this market minds waiting three weeks for something hand-finished, numbering runs naturally in order, and never reissued stays completely true.

Edition of 30, split 15 natural and 15 sumi, numbered within each. If one sells out and the other does not, that is useful information rather than a problem.

Order 40 of everything. Breakages, the photography set, press copies, and the parcels that go to makers.

Decision gate (unchanged): below 30% sell-through, pause physical and reassess pricing or audience before committing to edition two.

WHAT COMES AFTER THE FIRST 30

The ordering matters more than the choice.

1. **Fin DAC runs in parallel, starting now, not after the sell-out.** Send him a blank from this run. That piece is not a product decision, it is the photograph, and the photograph is what every Japanese maker conversation for the next two years opens with. Worth doing if it sells nothing. Waiting until December costs a year.
2. **Edition two is the same figure in a new finish, in spring.** No new development, no new base sizing, no new box, and the timings are already known. This is the Bearbrick pattern. State on the page from day one that the *edition* is never reissued, not the *form*. Collectors understand the difference and saying it now prevents looking like you broke your word later.
3. **The kokeshi collab is edition three**, when a Japanese turner makes an Auwa in solid wood from Rieko's form. Needs the printed books and the Fin DAC photograph in hand first. See `context/business/japan.md`.
4. **New story characters wait until the books are published.** A tanuki nobody has read about is a figure of nothing.

Advised against: a smaller, cheaper entry figure. Halving the size does not halve the work, because base, box, card and packing are fixed. £25 of packaging under a £55 figure does not work. If an entry-price object is ever wanted, make it a print.

THE COLLAB EDITIONS

Full programme context in `context/business/business.md` §6.2a and CLAUDE.md → THE COLLAB PROGRAMME. What follows is specific to the figure.

Not an open platform. Bearbrick can take anyone because their bear means nothing, which is why anything can be projected onto it. Auwa means something specific, and an open door turns the collection into a platform toy within two years. Curation is the asset.

The filter is how someone works, not what they depict. A thematic rule (only artists who paint nature, or Japan) would strangle the commercial line and produce a monotonous shelf. The test is: **could you recognise this person's work with their name removed?** If yes, they belong, whatever they paint. If no, they are decorating a figure and it is merchandise with extra steps.

Two filters sit alongside it. Their audience must overlap enough to sell ten pieces at £500-750, which means artists who already sell objects and editions rather than gallery names with waiting lists. And **the second collaborator should be Japanese**, not the fifth: if the first three are Western, the programme reads as a British brand borrowing Japan and every later craft approach gets harder.

Sequence after Fin DAC. A Japanese calligrapher is the strongest second or third piece: one brushstroke across a white Auwa is philosophically exact, since the reveal happens in a single gesture; it is fast and cheap to execute, photographs beautifully, and sits at the opposite visual end from Fin DAC, which shows the programme has range. Then Japanese tattoo artists (recognisable hands, large audiences who buy art), Kanazawa gold leaf (spectacular, bridges toward craft without a kiln), and illustrators with existing toy followings as the reliable commercial workhorses.

Brands are held. When the door opens, only to brands that make something and have a house hand you could recognise. A bank or a phone brand is advertising with an object attached. Year three at the earliest; doing one early would define the programme as merchandise before it is established as commission.

Pricing: off the collaborator's market, never off yours. Fin DAC's prints sell for a few hundred and his originals for thousands. Pricing a unique hand-painted piece at £250 because that feels like a figure price publicly undercuts his own market, and artists never forget that. An edition of around ten should sit near **£500-750**, and he should have a say in the number.

Structure: fifty-fifty on net, plus an allocation. The collaborator keeps a fifth to a third of the edition outright, and the net on the rest is split evenly after materials and fees. No fee up front, so no capital risk. The allocation is the marketing budget: when the artist posts a piece they own to their own audience, they are posting their own work, which reads completely differently from an advert.

One page, written down, precisely because he is a friend. The artwork stays their copyright, the form stays Auwa's, and neither party can reproduce the combined object without the other. Grant no rights to produce Auwa forms and ask for no rights over their artwork

elsewhere. Keep the master form and file unencumbered and grant nobody exclusivity, because that is what would close the licensing door later.

The approach: send the blank. You cannot pitch this in words. A written proposal describing a character figure decorated by artisans reads, in Japanese, uncomfortably close to a licensing solicitation. What goes in the parcel is **the blank figure in its kiribako, the two books, one photograph of the Fin DAC piece, and one page in their language.** No commercial ask at all. A proposal is ignored in a second; a blank white Auwa on an artist's desk is a question they keep looking at, and it answers itself the first morning they pick up a brush out of curiosity. The photograph's job is only to prove the idea produces something worth owning.

Naming grammar. "Auwa x [Artist]" is streetwear grammar and puts two brands side by side, which is the merchandise register. The collaborator's own Kokoro is what becomes visible, so the piece is **Auwa revealed by [Artist]**, with their name where an artist's name goes rather than where a co-brand goes.

Handling. Send three blanks, not one; artists ruin some and a second attempt should not need a transatlantic round trip. Insure the return leg. Box collab pieces in the same kiribako with the collaborator named on the obi band, so packaging cost stays flat and each collab needs no new development. Number them in their own series.

MANUFACTURING — SETTLED, DO NOT REOPEN

Do not outsource production of the Auwa-made line, ever. A factory will tool, mould, paint and box this for roughly £5,000-15,000 of tooling, minimum orders of 300-1,000, and single-digit unit costs after that. It is a good business at 500 units and £70 a piece. But it requires 500 buyers, sustained marketing to reach them, and a price point that says mass-produced, at which point hand-finished, signed, edition of thirty and never reissued all come off the page. That is the app problem in a new costume.

Silicone moulding and resin casting deletes the 40 minutes of sanding that dominates the labour, because a cast comes out smooth. It also deletes the wood composite and the material story with it, so it is wrong for the Auwa-made edition. It is right for exactly one thing: **casting the blanks sent to surface artists**, where the substrate is invisible because the artist's paint is the surface. That removes Rieko as the bottleneck on the collab line. Not until two or three collabs are in the pipeline at once.

Fulfilment is worth revisiting past a couple of hundred orders a year, never before, and the hand-written card and signature can never be outsourced.

Where the money actually is, per hour of hands: making figures is roughly £60/hour and capped. Artist collabs are roughly triple that and the collaborator's audience does the marketing. Craft collabs buy press and doors rather than cash. Licensing is the only line that pays without hands and it is gated entirely on the character becoming known, which is gated on the books. Every sold-out edition and documented collab is evidence for that conversation. See `context/pillar/book.md`.

RIEKO'S STEP-BY-STEP

The figure is hers end to end. Tom guides. Standalone version for printing:

`context/business/figure-rieko.md` → `documents/Auwa-Figure-Rieko.pdf`.

Decide first

1. **Settle the black with the books.** Character or finish? It sets the names, the copy and whether this is two characters or one figure in two colours.
2. **Freeze the form at 10cm.** Pick the date, then no more shape changes. Every later tweak restarts the printing, the base sizing and the box order.
3. **Specify the eyes.** Size, placement, colour, both versions. Faces are what people check across thirty units, so define it once rather than judging each time.

Test, in this order, one variable at a time

4. **Print the same figure at 0.2mm and 0.08mm.** Slower printing is machine time; sanding is her hands. Find out how much the finer layers save before committing to thirty.
5. **Sand one properly and time it.** That number sets the whole schedule.
6. **Stain tests.** White Oak and Black Walnut, several strengths, aiming for near-black with the grain still showing. Decides whether the sumi is the same material as the natural or a different one.
7. **Finish tests on sanded pieces.** Bare as control, camellia oil, hard wax. Pick by touch.
8. **Emboss a number on the underside and print it.** Check it is crisp at small size.
9. **Weigh one and decide if it needs mass.** Steel shot and a glued cap is three minutes a unit if it does.
10. **Post one to a friend abroad, boxed as it would be sold.** Find out about the legs now, not in December.

Source, starting immediately because these have the longest waits

11. **Kiribako.** Sample and price for roughly 14cm square by 10-11cm tall, fitted lid, single-board lid if possible, 40 boxes.
12. **Woodturner.** 40 hinoki or keyaki bases, about 9cm across, with shallow blind holes for the feet.
13. **Inner wrap.** Undyed cotton or washi, enough for 40.
14. **Brass stamp.** One mark for the base, the box lid and the card.

Then

15. **Design the obi band.** Logo, edition, number, on washi.
16. **Write one card as the template.** Her hand, her words, Japanese or both.
17. **Paint one test figure and put it away.** Keep it out of edition one so the blank stays the blank, but have it ready for when the artist line opens.

Held back deliberately. Rieko's hand-painted surface idea is good and it would make each piece individual, but the blank is the whole mechanic: the collab programme rests on an artist revealing an unmarked form. If edition one arrives already painted by Rieko, the Fin DAC piece becomes another painted one rather than the blank revealed. Let her painted version open the artist line instead. Same work, much better position in the sequence.

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Black Auwa: character or colourway? Blocks naming and store copy.
 - Final price: £220 recommended, not yet confirmed by Tom.
 - Base wood and supplier: Japan or UK for edition one.
 - Kiribako supplier and whether a 10-11cm tall box is a stock or custom item.
 - Whether the figure needs added mass.
 - EU/IOSS at launch, or UK and US only. See `context/website/store.md`.
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RELATED FILES

- `context/website/store.md` — the product page build brief, drop states, Shopify setup.

- `context/business/business.md` §6.2, §6.2a — the shelf and the collab programme in the wider plan.
- `context/business/japan.md` — maker relationships and the exhibition ladder.
- `context/business/structure.md` — VAT, trademark classes, trading entity.
- `context/brand/reference.md` — earlier collectible-figure rules, Fin DAC background, KAWS lessons.
- `context/pillar/book.md` — the publishing route, which gates everything priced off audience.
- Prototype photographs, the June Instagram post and the KAWS and Waso box references: `share/auwa-figure/prototype/` .